

THE HARE

Lepus



SIZE RANKING 51
BRIGHTEST STAR Arneb
 (α) 2.6
GENITIVE Leporis
ABBREVIATION Lep
HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM
 January
FULLY VISIBLE
 62°N–90°S



Lepus is often overlooked because it is surrounded by sparkling Orion and Canis Major, yet it is worthy of note. It is one of the constellations known to the ancient Greeks.

M79

This somewhat sparse 8th-magnitude globular cluster, 42,000 light-years away, has long, starry arms that give it the appearance of a starfish.

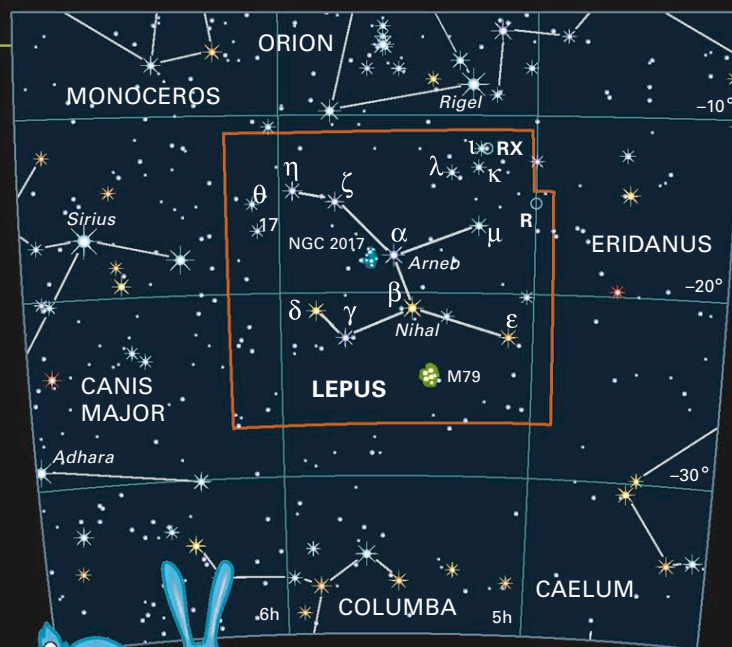
SPECIFIC FEATURES

Gamma (γ) Leporis is a 4th-magnitude yellow star with a 6th-magnitude orange companion, which is visible through binoculars. Another double star is Kappa (κ) Leporis, a 4th-magnitude star with a close companion of 7th magnitude. It is difficult to separate through telescopes of small aperture.

NGC 2017 is a compact group of stars in what seems to be a chance alignment. Thus it is not a true star cluster at all.

Near the border with Eridanus lies R Leporis, an intensely red variable star of the same type as Mira (in Cetus). Its brightness ranges from 6th to 12th magnitude every 14 months or so.

The globular cluster M79 can be seen though a small telescope. In the same field of view lies Herschel 3752, a triple star with components of 5th, 7th, and 9th magnitudes.



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NGC 2017

This open cluster consists of a 6th-magnitude star with four companions of 8th to 10th magnitude, which are visible through a small telescope. Larger apertures reveal three fainter stars in the group.



MYTHS AND STORIES

A RUNNING HARE

According to Greek mythology, there were no hares on the island of Leros until one man introduced a pregnant female. Soon everyone was raising hares, but they became pests, destroying crops and reducing the population to starvation. The inhabitants eventually drove the hares out of the island and put the image of the hare among the stars as a reminder that one can have too much of a good thing.

THE HUNTER AND HUNTED

One of Orion's dogs chases the hare in this 15th-century Flemish illustration, which was based on the *Liber Floridus* of Lambertus, compiled during the Middle Ages.

SAFE HAVEN

Lepus, the celestial hare, crouches under the feet of Orion, like an animal trying to hide from its hunter. Orion's dogs, Canis Major and Canis Minor, lie nearby.